

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit II – Empathy and Problem Definition · Presentation 4 of 6

Interviews and Need Finding

Why interviews go wrong · the interview funnel · good and bad questions · laddering and the five whys · stated, observed and latent needs

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In this presentation

- Why interviews go wrong
- The interview funnel
- Two kinds of question
- Writing an interview guide
- The five whys
- Laddering beneath the answer
- Three kinds of need
- Capturing what you heard

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Asking well

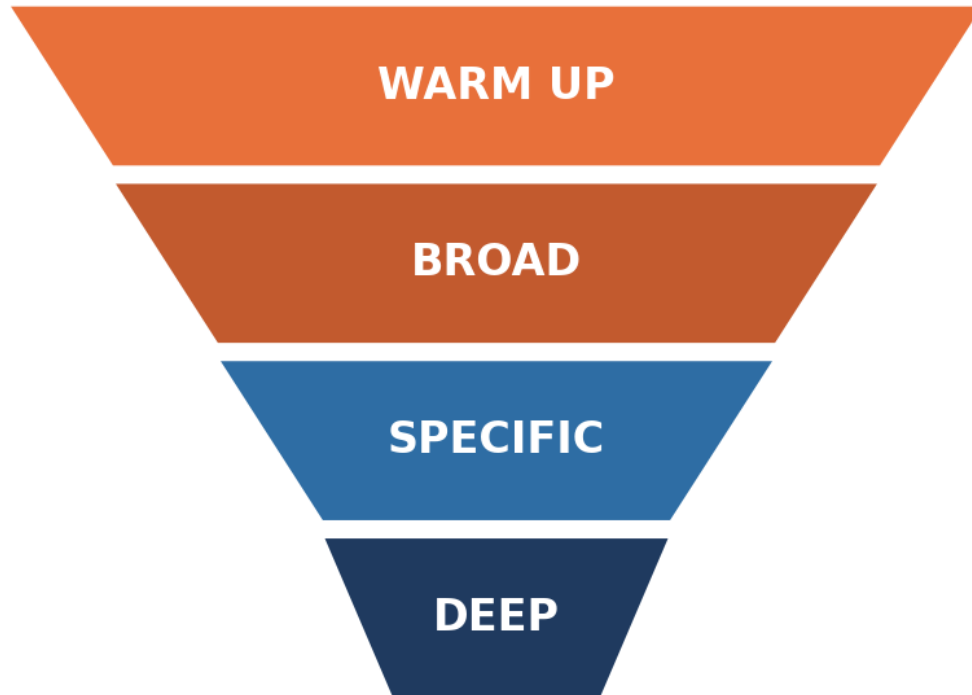
Most bad interview data is created by the interviewer

Why interviews go wrong

- Leading questions return the answer you already expected to hear
- Hypothetical questions (“would you use...”) return polite fiction
- People want to help you, so they agree with your idea
- Asking about the general case gets a generalisation, not an event

KEY POINT Never ask whether they would use your idea. Ask what they did the last time the problem actually happened.

The interview funnel



"Tell me a little about your day."

"Tell me about the last time you did X."

"What happened then? What did you do next?"

"Why did that matter to you?"

open wide, then narrow — never the other way round

Start wide and comfortable; narrow only once the story is running.

Two kinds of question

Ask this

- Tell me about the last time...
- Walk me through how you...
- Why was that difficult?
- What did you do instead?

Not this

- Would you use an app that...
- Do you think X is a problem?
- Don't you find X annoying?
- How often do you usually...

KEY POINT A good question cannot be answered yes or no, and does not contain your idea anywhere inside it.

Writing an interview guide

- Eight to ten questions on a single page – you will not use them all
- Open with something easy and factual, to settle the person
- Put the sensitive questions late, once there is a little trust
- Leave silence after an answer; people fill it with the real answer

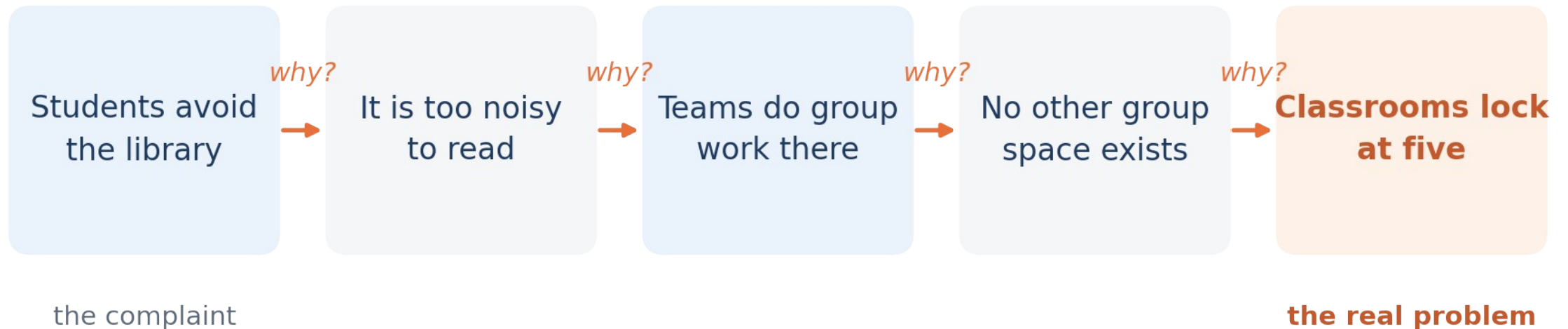
ACTIVITY Ten minutes. Write five questions for your team's user, swap with another team, and mark every leading question you can find.

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Getting beneath the answer

The first answer is the complaint, not the problem

The five whys



five is a guide, not a rule — stop when the answer stops changing

Each “why” moves from the symptom towards something you can act on.

Laddering beneath the answer

- Every “why” moves you from the symptom towards a cause you can change
- Ask gently and vary the wording, or it turns into an interrogation
- Stop when the answer stops changing, or when you reach something outside your reach
- Ladder downwards too, with “how” and “what exactly” – abstraction hides the detail

KEY POINT The first answer is almost never the problem. It is the complaint about the problem.

Three kinds of need

Kind	How you find it	Example
Stated	They tell you directly	“I want a faster printer”
Observed	You watch them work	They print twice because page one jams
Latent	Inferred from the gap	They need to stop checking, not to print faster

Stated needs are the easiest to collect and the least valuable. Latent needs are where the design opportunity sits.

Latent needs

- Needs people cannot state, because they stopped noticing the problem long ago
- Found by combining what you watched with what you were told – not by asking harder
- Always phrased as a verb: “needs to know it worked”, not “needs a status light”
- Test one by describing it back; if they say “yes, exactly”, you have it

KEY POINT If you can state a need the user could not state, and they recognise it, you have done need finding.

Capturing what you heard

- Two people per interview: one asks, one writes
- Quotations marked as quotations; inferences marked as inferences
- Within the hour, each interviewer writes the three things that surprised them
- Put the quotations on a wall where the whole team can see them

KEY POINT Evidence nobody else can see is evidence that will lose the argument.

THINK ABOUT IT

Think of the last time somebody asked you a leading question. What did you answer, and was it true?

- What made the easy answer easier than the accurate one?
- How would you have answered a better question?
- Which of your own questions does this apply to?
- How will you catch yourself doing it in the field?

Summary

- Leading and hypothetical questions manufacture the data they find
- Open wide, then narrow – and ask about specific past events
- A guide is one page, easy first, sensitive last, silence throughout
- Laddering and the five whys move from complaint to cause
- Needs come stated, observed and latent; latent needs are the prize
- A need is a verb, and the evidence goes where the team can see it

Next: Problem identification and framing

- Turning field notes into insight
- What makes a problem statement well framed
- Weak and strong statements compared
- Writing How Might We questions